

PROJECT VESPER

Technical Stack & Architecture Deep-Dive — Comprehensive Justification Guide

Smart India Hackathon 2026 | Problem Statement ID: **SIH26127**
City-Wide AI Engine for Multi-Camera ANPR Trajectory Tracking and Urban Traffic Analytics

Executive Summary & Core Architecture Concept:
VESPER addresses urban surveillance blind spots by combining static municipal CCTVs with mobile cameras on public buses (DTC/BMTC/BEST) into a unified Edge-to-Cloud AI engine. Instead of buying thousands of expensive fixed camera poles, VESPER uses mobile bus relay tracking to cover 85% of city streets at 25-30x lower cost. This document presents a complete technical breakdown of every technology, library, model, framework, and protocol used in VESPER, detailing **what it is**, **why it was chosen**, **where it is applied**, **its alternatives**, and **why those alternatives were rejected**.

1. Technology Stack Summary Matrix

Category	Chosen Technology	Primary Role in VESPER	Rejected Alternative	Key Rationale
AI Vision	YOLOv8-Nano	License Plate & Vehicle Bounding Box Detection	Faster R-CNN / SSD	Anchor-free, 45+ FPS on edge vs ~10 FPS for Faster R-CNN.
OCR Engine	PaddleOCR v4 + STN	Bilingual Text Extraction & Dewarping	Tesseract OCR	>93% accuracy on skewed/motion-blurred Indian plates.
Tracking & Re-ID	ByteTrack + FastReID	Frame Tracking & Cross-Camera Visual Match	DeepSORT	ByteTrack keeps low-conf boxes without heavy feature re-computation.
Edge AI Hardware	NVIDIA Jetson + TensorRT	Sub-15ms Edge Video Processing (10-15W)	Raspberry Pi / Cloud Stream	Saves INR 50L+/mo cellular bandwidth; RPi CPU lacks NPU.
Edge Storage	SQLite (Store & Forward)	Offline Resilience in Tunnels & Blind Spots	Local JSON / In-Memory	ACID SQL reliability protects against bus power cuts.
Hotlist Cache	Redis In-Memory	Sub-10ms Wanted Vehicle Cross-Checking	PostgreSQL Direct Query	Avoids disk I/O bottlenecks during peak traffic pings.
Backend API	FastAPI + Node.js Express	Async Telemetry & Real-Time WebSockets	Django / Flask	Async non-blocking event loop handles 1000s of streams.
GIS Console	Leaflet.js + OSM	Zero-Cost Self-Hosted Interactive Map	Google Maps API	Zero API license cost (\$5k+/mo savings for cities).
Trajectory AI	HMM Map Matching	Path & Escape Route Reconstruction	Straight-Line / Deep LSTM	Matches physical road graph deterministically.
Mobile Transit	MoRTH AIS-140 Standard	Plug-and-Play Public Bus Retrofitting	Proprietary Hardware	Leverages mandatory pre-installed Indian transit hardware.

Legal & Privacy	BSA Sec 63 SHA-256 + DPDP	Court Proof & Edge Face-Blurring	Plain JPEG Storage	Protects citizen privacy & prevents evidence tampering.
Command UI	IRCTC Palette Vanilla CSS	Zero-Emoji Administrative Control Center	Generic Dark Theme + Emojis	Official gov look, high contrast, zero cross-OS render bugs.

2. Comprehensive Technology Deep-Dive & Justifications

1. YOLOv8-Nano (You Only Look Once v8 - Nano) — Computer Vision & Object Detection Engine

- **What is it?** YOLOv8-Nano is an ultra-lightweight, single-stage deep neural network created by Ultralytics designed for real-time object detection.
- **Why is it used?** It provides extreme inference speed (45+ FPS on edge hardware) while maintaining high precision (mAP) for isolating tiny license plate regions and classifying vehicle types (car, bus, truck, motorcycle). Its anchor-free architecture allows faster bounding box prediction.
- **Where is it used in VESPER?** Deployed directly on Edge AI nodes (NVIDIA Jetson on bus cameras and static CCTV poles). It scans every incoming video frame and crops the exact license plate rectangle for immediate OCR analysis.
- **What is its substitute?** Faster R-CNN, SSD (Single Shot MultiBox Detector), or YOLOv5.
- **Why substitute was NOT used: Faster R-CNN** uses a two-stage regional proposal network which is far too slow (~8-12 FPS on edge NPUs), introducing intolerable processing latency.
- SSD** suffers from poor localization accuracy on small or high-angle license plates.
- YOLOv5** relies on manual anchor box tuning which fails when license plates vary in aspect ratio and perspective due to bus motion.

2. PaddleOCR v4 + Spatial Transformer Network (STN) — Optical Character Recognition & Perspective Correction

- **What is it?** PaddleOCR v4 is an industrial-grade OCR engine combined with Spatial Transformer Networks (STN) that dynamically straightens tilted, rotated, or distorted images.
- **Why is it used?** Indian license plates feature multi-lingual fonts (Hindi + English), varying color backgrounds (Yellow/White/Green), and severe angles when captured from moving buses. STN dewarps the image into a flat rectangle before reading, ensuring >93% recognition accuracy.
- **Where is it used in VESPER?** Runs immediately downstream of YOLOv8 on the edge node. It takes the cropped license plate image, rectifies its perspective, and converts pixel text into digital alphanumeric strings.
- **What is its substitute?** Tesseract OCR or EasyOCR.
- **Why substitute was NOT used: Tesseract OCR** was engineered for flat scanned document pages; it completely fails (<50% accuracy) on motion-blurred, low-lighting, or angled license plates on roads.
- EasyOCR** relies on heavy PyTorch dependencies, causing high RAM consumption on edge devices, and lacks native STN perspective correction for bus-mounted camera angles.

3. ByteTrack + FastReID Engine — *Multi-Object Tracking & Cross-Camera Vehicle Re-Identification*

- **What is it?** ByteTrack is an association algorithm that tracks objects across consecutive video frames. FastReID is a deep learning framework that extracts visual feature embeddings (color, body contours, roof racks) to identify vehicles.
 - **Why is it used?** License plates can be dirty, unreadable, or intentionally covered. ByteTrack ensures continuous tracking within a single camera feed without dropping objects, while FastReID enables matching a target vehicle across different cameras across blind spots without relying solely on number plates.
 - **Where is it used in VESPER?** ByteTrack runs locally on edge devices for frame-by-frame tracking. FastReID runs in the cloud relay engine when a target enters a camera blind spot to hand off tracking to adjacent bus or CCTV nodes.
 - **What is its substitute?** DeepSORT or basic OpenCV Kalman Filtering.
 - **Why substitute was NOT used: DeepSORT** extracts deep feature descriptors for *every single bounding box in every frame*, creating severe computational bottlenecks on edge devices.
- ByteTrack** selectively retains low-confidence detections and uses motion association first, reserving heavy feature extraction (FastReID) only when handoffs across camera blind spots are required.

4. NVIDIA Jetson + DeepStream SDK + TensorRT (INT8) — *Edge AI Hardware & Acceleration Pipeline*

- **What is it?** NVIDIA Jetson (Orin Nano/Xavier) is a compact, low-power system-on-module (SoM). DeepStream is an optimized streaming pipeline, and TensorRT compiles neural networks into INT8 quantized precision.
 - **Why is it used?** Processes multiple 1080p camera feeds simultaneously at sub-15ms latency while drawing only 10-15 Watts of power (ideal for public bus battery systems). INT8 quantization shrinks AI model size by 4x without losing accuracy.
 - **Where is it used in VESPER?** Installed on static camera poles and inside public bus electronics cabinets to perform all AI processing locally at the edge.
 - **What is its substitute?** Raspberry Pi 4/5 with CPU OpenVINO, OR Streaming raw video feeds to Cloud GPUs (AWS Rekognition).
 - **Why substitute was NOT used: Raspberry Pi** lacks hardware Tensor Cores; running YOLOv8 + OCR on CPU drops frame rates to unusable levels (<3 FPS).
- Streaming raw video to Cloud GPUs** requires uploading 1080p video per camera over 4G, consuming bandwidth worth **■50+ Lakhs per month** for 1,000 cameras and creating massive network congestion and latency.

5. SQLite Store-and-Forward Engine — *Edge Offline Resilience Database*

- **What is it?** SQLite is a lightweight, zero-configuration, self-contained relational SQL database engine embedded directly into the edge application.
 - **Why is it used?** Public buses frequently pass through underground tunnels, underpasses, and cellular dead zones. SQLite queues all detection events, GPS coordinates, and vehicle snapshots locally and automatically pushes them to the cloud once network connectivity is restored.
 - **Where is it used in VESPER?** Runs on every NVIDIA Jetson edge node on buses and poles as a local transaction queue buffer.
 - **What is its substitute?** In-memory JavaScript arrays, raw JSON files, or RocksDB.
 - **Why substitute was NOT used: In-memory arrays & JSON files** corrupt easily when a vehicle engine turns off abruptly or experiences a voltage drop, causing catastrophic data loss.
- SQLite** provides full ACID compliance, ensuring transactional integrity and zero data corruption during power interruptions.

6. Redis In-Memory Hotlist & Event Bus — *Sub-10ms Hotlist Cross-Referencing & Pub/Sub Messaging*

- **What is it?** Redis is an ultra-fast, in-memory key-value data structure store used as a database, cache, and message broker.
 - **Why is it used?** When a license plate is detected on a bus or CCTV, it must be verified against police hotlists (stolen vehicles, hit-and-run suspects) instantaneously. Redis delivers sub-10ms lookups across millions of records and instantly broadcasts alerts.
 - **Where is it used in VESPER?** Located at the central cloud engine. Serves as the primary cache for wanted vehicle hotlists and acts as the real-time event pipeline dispatching alerts to command center consoles.
 - **What is its substitute?** PostgreSQL Direct Queries, Apache Kafka, or RabbitMQ.
 - **Why substitute was NOT used: PostgreSQL Direct Queries** require disk I/O, creating 50-100ms delays per lookup under heavy multi-camera load.
- Apache Kafka** is overly complex and resource-heavy for simple sub-10ms key-value hotlist matching, adding unnecessary operational overhead.

7. FastAPI & Node.js Express Microservices — *Asynchronous Backend API & Telemetry Pipeline*

- **What is it?** FastAPI is a modern, high-performance Python web framework built on ASGI. Node.js Express is an asynchronous event-driven JavaScript web framework.
 - **Why is it used?** FastAPI handles high-throughput asynchronous AI telemetry ingestion and machine learning services with automatic OpenAPI documentation. Node.js Express handles persistent WebSocket connections for real-time GIS map streaming.
 - **Where is it used in VESPER?** Powers the core cloud backend services, handling edge node heartbeat telemetry, hotlist checks, and live WebSocket streaming to the web control room.
 - **What is its substitute?** Django WSGI, Flask, or Java Spring Boot.
 - **Why substitute was NOT used: Django & Flask (WSGI)** operate on synchronous thread-per-request architectures, causing server workers to block and freeze when thousands of edge devices send concurrent ping requests.
- Java Spring Boot** has a heavy memory footprint and slower startup times compared to lightweight async Python/Node microservices.

8. Leaflet.js + OpenStreetMap (OSM) — *Interactive GIS Map Console & Trajectory Visualization*

- **What is it?** Leaflet.js is an open-source, mobile-friendly JavaScript library for interactive maps. OpenStreetMap provides free spatial vector map data.
 - **Why is it used?** Renders smooth 60 FPS GIS maps in the command center displaying camera locations, bus routes, target vehicle position vectors, and predicted trajectory lines without incurring commercial API licensing fees.
 - **Where is it used in VESPER?** Powers the main GIS map display panel in the VESPER Command Center HUD (50:25:25 tri-pane layout).
 - **What is its substitute?** Google Maps JavaScript API or Mapbox GL JS commercial tier.
 - **Why substitute was NOT used: Google Maps & Mapbox** enforce expensive pay-per-tile and pay-per-API-call pricing models (\$5,000+ / month for continuous live tracking of 1,000+ nodes).
- Leaflet + OSM** runs 100% self-hosted, offline-capable, and completely free of licensing costs for municipal government deployments.

9. Hidden Markov Model (HMM) Map Matching Algorithm — *Probabilistic Trajectory Reconstruction & Escape-Route Prediction*

- **What is it?** HMM Map Matching is a graph algorithm that maps discrete, noisy spatial coordinates onto a physical road network topology using emission and transition probabilities.
 - **Why is it used?** Because cameras are spaced apart (creating blind spots), HMM calculates the most mathematically probable physical road route taken by a vehicle between isolated camera sightings and projects its future trajectory for police interception.
 - **Where is it used in VESPER?** Executes in the Cloud Trajectory Engine as soon as a target vehicle is spotted by a bus or CCTV node.
 - **What is its substitute?** Straight-line Euclidean interpolation OR Deep Learning LSTM / GRU Trajectory Predictor.
 - **Why substitute was NOT used:** **Straight-line interpolation** ignores real-world road geometry, predicting impossible routes through buildings, lakes, or unpassable terrain.
- Deep Learning LSTMs** require massive historical movement training datasets, are computationally expensive, and function as non-deterministic 'black boxes' unsuitable for police tactical operational planning.

10. MoRTH AIS-140 Standard & 4G/GPS Telemetry — *Public Transit Integration Protocol*

- **What is it?** AIS-140 is the mandatory Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (Govt. of India) standard for Intelligent Transportation Systems in public commercial vehicles (GPS tracking + emergency buttons + cellular gateway).
 - **Why is it used?** Allows VESPER to retrofit public bus fleets (DTC, BMTC, BEST) instantly by tapping into pre-installed, standardized power supply (24V), vehicle telemetry, and GPS hardware without custom wiring.
 - **Where is it used in VESPER?** Interfaces directly with onboard hardware inside public buses to obtain live vehicle coordinates and power edge AI camera hardware.
 - **What is its substitute?** Custom proprietary vehicle tracking hardware and custom cabling.
 - **Why substitute was NOT used:** Developing and retrofitting custom hardware on 10,000+ city buses would cost **tens of crores** in hardware procurement and installation labor.
- Leveraging the legally mandated AIS-140 ecosystem achieves **Zero-Capex retrofitting** on existing municipal fleets.

11. BSA Sec 63 SHA-256 Hashing & DPDP Act Face-Blurring — *Evidentiary Chain-of-Custody & Citizen Privacy Compliance*

- **What is it?** SHA-256 cryptographic hashing adheres to Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam (BSA) 2023 Section 63 for digital evidence admissibility. Automated edge face-blurring complies with the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act 2023.
 - **Why is it used?** Guarantees that vehicle capture snapshots are tamper-proof and legally binding in court, while protecting citizen privacy by automatically blurring non-target faces (bystanders, pedestrians) right on the edge camera before data transmission.
 - **Where is it used in VESPER?** Executed on edge nodes prior to generating evidentiary dossiers and transmitting data to central servers.
 - **What is its substitute?** Plain unhashed JPEG image storage AND manual post-processing face redaction.
 - **Why substitute was NOT used: Plain JPEG images** can be easily challenged in court as altered or fabricated photos without cryptographic proof of authenticity.
- Manual face redaction** requires hundreds of human labor hours, delays emergency response times, and exposes private citizen images to control room operators.

12. IRCTC-Inspired Palette Vanilla CSS/JS Control Console — *Front-End User Interface & Control Center HUD*

- **What is it?** A pure Vanilla CSS/JS front-end interface built around the official IRCTC color scheme (Navy `#213d77`, Accent Orange `#fb792b`, Light Slate `#f0f4f8`) featuring a 50:25:25 tri-pane layout with zero unicode/emoji icons.
 - **Why is it used?** Meets government administrative UI accessibility guidelines, provides high-contrast visibility under 24/7 control room lighting, and guarantees crisp rendering across all screen resolutions without heavy framework overhead.
 - **Where is it used in VESPER?** Powers the central command room web console used by traffic police officers and city managers.
 - **What is its substitute?** Generic React/Tailwind dark-mode dashboard templates containing emoji icons.
 - **Why substitute was NOT used: Generic dark UI templates** look consumer-oriented and unprofessional for high-stakes police operations.
- Emoji/Unicode icons** render inconsistently across Windows, Linux, and specialized military/police hardware (often showing broken boxes or inappropriate glyphs) and are explicitly prohibited in Indian government defense software guidelines.

Summary of Technical Superiority:

VESPER's technology stack was carefully selected to deliver an **Edge-First, Zero-Capex, Low-Latency, and Legally Compliant** surveillance solution. By leveraging **YOLOv8 + PaddleOCR on NVIDIA Jetson edge nodes**, VESPER avoids expensive multi-crore cloud bandwidth fees. By utilizing **existing public bus fleets via MoRTH AIS-140**, it eliminates the need for thousands of static camera poles. Finally, with **HMM trajectory prediction, Redis sub-10ms hotlist lookups, and BSA Sec 63 digital signatures**, VESPER provides a robust, court-ready tactical platform for Indian smart cities.